



The civil war in Korea quickly escalated and drew in troops from across the world under UN command, including these British machine gunners.

**“WE SHALL
LAND AT INCHON,
AND I SHALL
CRUSH THEM.”**

Douglas MacArthur, US General, 1950

AFTER NEARLY 100 YEARS OF BRITISH RULE,

India became a **republic** on January 26. India had been managing its own affairs since the partition in 1947, but this day marked the official cutting of all ties. In a formal ceremony, **president Rajendra Prasad** (1884–1963) took the oath of office and a new constitution came into force.



Emblem of India
India adopted this emblem, taken from a sculpture called Lion Capital of Ashoka, after it became a republic. The words “truth alone triumphs” are inscribed in Devanagari script.

to witness **increasing racial tension**. Whites and blacks were segregated on a large scale, and **identity cards**

specifying a person's race were introduced. On May 1, a **general strike** was held protesting against all discriminatory laws. **Police opened fire** in the Alexandria Township, killing 18 people and wounding 30.

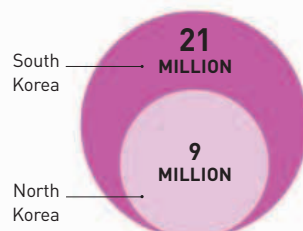
A year after communists had assumed power in **China** they invaded neighbouring **Tibet**. The military assault took place in October, and by April 1951, Tibet's leaders claimed to have been strong-armed into signing a treaty, known as the “**Seventeen Point Agreement**,” which gave China control over Tibet's external affairs and allowed **Chinese military occupation**.

Anti-communist witch-hunter **Senator Joseph McCarthy** launched a “red scare” crusade in America on February 9, claiming that the US State Department was harbouring 205 communists. His claims were never substantiated,

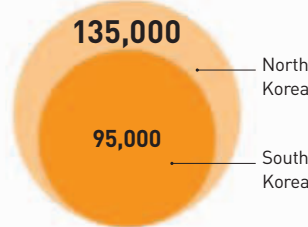
but many lost their jobs and their reputations (see 1954).

In June, a **new crisis** divided former wartime allies in **Korea**. Split into a Soviet-occupied northern zone and an American-occupied southern zone, once these two powers had withdrawn, the **north**—still backed by the USSR—**invaded the south**.

The US, determined not to appease the Russians, provided the main contingent for a **United Nations army** that went to the support of the South Koreans. Within four months, the UN force had driven deep into North Korea; only the intervention of **China** saved North Korea from collapse (see 1953).



POPULATION IN 1950



ARMY SIZE IN 1950

Korean population and army
Despite having less than half the population of South Korea in 1950, North Korea's army was superior in size and much better equipped.



McCARTHYISM

Named for senator Joseph McCarthy (1908–57), McCarthyism became synonymous with the hunt for communists in US public life during the 1950s. The triumph of communism in Eastern Europe and China provoked a severe crisis in the US. Fears of a worldwide communist conspiracy resulted in a campaign against people suspected of communist leanings. McCarthy held senate hearings to “out” communists, and so-called “anti-American” books were removed from public libraries.

The **first human organ transplant** took place on June 17 at the Little Company of Mary Hospital in Illinois. A kidney from a dead body was used to replace a damaged kidney. Although it was later rejected, the transplant gave the patient's remaining kidney time to recover.

German-born physicist **Albert Einstein** (see 1919), who had become actively involved in advocating nuclear disarmament and civil rights, published “**On the Generalized Theory of Gravitation**” in April's *Scientific American*. In this paper, he attempted to unify **gravity** and

electro-magnetism in a way that led to a new understanding of **quantum mechanics**.

The first **modern credit card**, which could be used at a variety of stores, was introduced in the US by Diners Club on February 8. It was established mostly for businessmen to use for travel and entertainment expenses. Cardholders had up to 60 days to pay in full. Merchants were quick to accept the card because they found that **customers** who used a credit card **usually spent more** if they were able to “charge it.”

**“COMMUNISM
IS A HAMMER
THAT WE USE
TO CRUSH THE
ENEMY.”**

Mao Zedong, 1950

